

cover story PAKISTAN ELECTIONS

fray in protest against the sacking of the judiciary, describes the results as, "the turning point in Pakistan's history that could result in a genuine democracy."

In his Model Town house at a suburb in Lahore, Sharif looks very much like the cat which has licked the cream. It is a remarkable turnaround for a man who had to spend almost eight years in an ignominious exile in Jeddah and was humiliatingly deported in his first attempt at returning to his homeland last year. As his supporters beat their dhols deliriously, the drums of history seem to be playing to Sharif's beat again. Looking relaxed he told INDIA TODAY, "The people have said Mr Musharraf we have had enough of you. We want democracy and not dictatorship. Today Mr Musharraf must be a very worried man." (see interview)

In Islamabad, inside the President's office cordoned off by rows of barbed wire, Musharraf seems clearly shaken by the results. His close aides say he has gone "quiet" and acknowledge that he looks disappointed. While critics grudgingly concede that Musharraf redeemed himself by holding a reasonably free and fair election, his position has been rendered even more tenuous with the rout of the King's party. Coming after his disastrous sacking of the top judiciary, the brief imposition of Emergency and his being forced to give up his uniform, Musharraf is now a shadow of the man who, despite being a dictator, had charmed the world including India

with his candour and articulation. His aides bravely maintain that there is no need for him to listen to demands for quitting. His spokesperson, Major General Rashid Quereshi (retd), says: "This was not an election for the President. President Musharraf has already been elected for five years." But it is clear that the ground is slipping rapidly beneath the President's feet.

Everything now depends on how Zardari and PPP go about the tricky business of putting together a coalition government in the coming weeks. The sympathy wave for Bhutto has swept the party to its best show in 15 years. Of the 268 National Assembly (NA) seats being directly contested in the February 18 elections, PPP has emerged victorious on 88, becoming the single largest party in Pakistan. In the province of Sindh—the Bhutto heartland—PPP has won over 50 per cent of the 129 seats being contested for the provincial legislature, which has put it into the position of forming a government on its own there, if it so chooses. PPP has also emerged as the only political party with substantial representation in all the four provinces of Pakistan, strengthening claims of party activists that it is the only truly national party. Aside from Sindh, where it has a majority, it is in a position to form coalition governments in at least two of the other three provinces (see graphic).

But PPP's results—impressive as they are—are nowhere near as stunning as what else happened on the election day. Contrary to most pundits'

"I will ensure t

Soon after his party emerged as the single largest in the current elections, a confident Asif Ali Zardari, widower of Benazir Bhutto and co-chairperson of the Pakistan Peoples Party, spoke exclusively to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA at his Islamabad house about the challenges that lay ahead. Excerpts:

Q. Were you disappointed that your party didn't win a simple majority on its own?

A. No, considering the circumstances. It's like if you have an army which is fighting a war and you lose your general and in spite of that your army manages to win the battle. But our victory was against all odds. Everyone knows the kind of rigging that took place.

Q. In forming a coalition government what would be your approach?

A. The nation is in a disarray, there is no governance and institutions have been weakened. Therefore, I am calling for a national consensus to put the government right.

Q. Would this include the King's party, the PML(Q)?

A. PML(Q) has never been a political party. It is a collection of individuals. Now the elections have exposed them. So where is the question of an alliance?

Q. Nawaz Sharif has said the main



The Likely Coalitions

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Total Seats 342 (including 60 seats reserved for women and 10 seats reserved for minorities allocated on proportional basis to parties). To form a government, a simple majority of 172 seats is required.

PROJECTED TOTALS (incl reserved seats)

PPP	113	MQM	25
PML(N)	84	ANP	14
PML(Q)	55	MMA	7
Independents / Others 39			

(Note: Election on four seats has been postponed, result of one seat is still awaited)

COALITION*

PPP
+
PML(N)
+
ANP

Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP); Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N); Pakistan Muslim League-Quaid-e-Azam (PML-Q); Muttahida Quami Movement (MQM); Awami National Party (ANP); Muttahida Majlis-e-Amal (MMA)